Safe-Seat Washington

How often is a Washingtonian's legislative or congressional general election an actual contest? (Observed, 2016–2024)

Companion to "Who Decides Washington?" and the electoral-health white paper (Finding 2). Where the lead paper showed who turns out, *this one asks whether their vote in the general is a real choice. Figures from `scripts/diag_safe_seat_wa.py`, computed from observed precinct results (`precinct_results`), not the forecast model.*

The question, and why "observed" matters

The standard "most seats are safe" claim usually rests on a *projection* — a model's predicted margin. That invites the obvious rebuttal: *your model could be wrong.* So this paper throws the projection out and counts the **actual** general-election result of every partisan legislative and congressional seat on Washington's ballot, 2016–2024. The unit is the **seat** (each State Representative position, each State Senator race up that cycle, each U.S. House race) — the thing a voter actually marks.

Washington's **top-two primary** sharpens the question. Because the two highest primary finishers advance regardless of party, a general can be (a) **uncontested** (one candidate), (b) **same-party** — two Democrats or two Republicans, so the general offers *no major-party choice at all* — or (c) a real **D-vs-R** contest, which we then band by two-party margin (Tossup <5 / Lean 5–10 / Likely 10–20 / Solid ≥20). A seat is **non-competitive** if it is uncontested, same-party, or D-vs-R by ≥10 points.

What the data shows

Observed competitiveness of partisan legislative + congressional seats, by even-year general:

Year	Seats	Uncontested	Same-party	Tossup	Lean	Likely	Solid	Non-competitive
2016	107	20	27	4	6	18	32	**90.7%**
2018	100	8	12	16	9	19	36	**75.0%**
2020	132	14	21	10	11	24	52	**84.1%**
2022	132	23	23	9	8	26	43	**87.1%**
2024	133	23	23	10	10	21	46	**85.0%**

- **Defensible claim.** In a typical Washington cycle, **roughly 85% of legislative and congressional seats are decided before November.** In 2024, of 133 partisan seats only **20 (15%) were genuine contests** (within 10 points); **113 were non-competitive**, and **46 of them — more than a third of all seats — offered voters no D-vs-R choice whatsoever** (23 uncontested + 23 same-party top-two generals). The pattern is stable across a decade (84–91%), denting **only** in the 2018 blue-wave year, when competition briefly rose (non-competitive fell to 75%). This is a counting result on real ballots — it does not depend on any model.
- **It is not a one-party artifact.** Among 2024's safe seats, **69 lean Democratic and 44 lean Republican** — safe seats are a bipartisan feature of the map, the expected product of a geographically sorted electorate, not a gerrymander story.
- **The model that the cross-state work relies on is validated here.** This project's forecast independently bands **53 of 59** WA districts as ≥10-pt safe (**90%**) for 2026 — within a few points of the **85%** measured on actual 2024 results. The projection and the observed record agree.

The operative contest is the lower-turnout primary. When the November general is foregone, the binding decision is the August top-two primary — which drew only **~51% of the general's voters in 2024** (median across seats; ~62% in 2022). So in a safe seat the effective choice is made by an electorate roughly **half** the size of the one that shows up to ratify it in November — and, per the lead paper, an off-cycle *local* primary electorate is smaller and older still.

The strongest objection (and the honest limit)

- **Lopsided ≠ illegitimate.** A Solid-D Seattle seat and a Solid-R rural seat each *represent* their electorate; a 40-point margin can simply mean the voters there genuinely agree, which is the healthy null ("outcomes reflect voter choice"), not a closed shop. The finding is strongest for the **46 no-choice seats** (uncontested + same-party), where the general offered no cross-party option at all — and weakest as a "democratic failure" reading for the merely-lopsided Solid seats.

- **The threshold is a knob.** "Non-competitive" is sensitive to the 10-point cutoff; the *uncontested + same-party* count (35% of 2024 seats) is threshold-free and is the hardest part of the claim to argue with.
- **WA's top-two makes "same-party" a Washington-specific category.** In states with party primaries the analogue is "no major-party filer." The four-state table below folds both into a single comparable bucket — *no major-party choice* — so the cross- state counts are apples-to-apples.

The four-state map — observed

Running the **same observed count** against each state's **lower chamber** — the one body fully up every cycle in all four states, so the count is complete and apples-to-apples (upper chambers stagger in WA/TX and are reported separately below; `scripts/diag_safe_seat_states.py`). Most recent loaded general: WA/TX/ID 2024; NY 2022.

State (chamber)	Seats	No major-party choice	Competitive (<10pt)	Non-competitive	Safe D / R	(model proj.)
WA House	98	39	11	**88.8%**	54 / 33	90%
NY Assembly	149	48	17	**88.6%**	89 / 43	86%
TX House*	150	61	9	**94.0%**	51 / 90	81%
ID House	70	20	5	**92.9%**	8 / 57	92%

- **Defensible claim.** Safe-seat dominance is **not a Washington peculiarity** — in every one of the four states **89–94% of lower-chamber seats were non-competitive** on the actual ballot, blue and red alike, and **a third or more offered no D-vs-R choice at all** (WA 39, NY 48, TX 61, ID 20). And the observed counts **track the model's independent projection** (NY 88.6 observed vs 86 projected; ID 92.9 vs 92; WA 88.8 vs 90) — the projection the cross-state work leans on is validated against real ballots. Safe seats favor the locally dominant party (WA/NY lean-D, TX/ID lean-R) — partisan geography, symmetric: lopsided seats exist on both sides everywhere.
- **TX is the most foreclosed — and the contest gap is *worse* than the map.** Completed to all 150 House seats (see below), **94%** were non-competitive and **61 (41%) had no major-party opponent.** Strikingly, that 94% *exceeds* what the district lean predicts: the 2024 **presidential** result bands only **84%** of TX House districts as ≥10-pt safe (close to the model's 81% projection), yet **94%** of the actual House *races* were foregone — Texas parties decline to field candidates even in seats their own presidential numbers say are winnable. Observed contestation is worse than the partisan geography alone.
- ***TX backfill.** The TLC canvass-grade VTD returns omit uncontested races (no precinct tally is published when a seat is unopposed), so the warehouse carried only 96/150 TX House districts. The 54 absent seats are uncontested by construction — confirmed against the press-reported 2024 unopposed list (HD 35/36/38/40/42/49/51/75/78/79/90/92/95 D, 81 R, ..., all in the missing set) — and are backfilled as *no-major-choice*, with holding party assigned by each district's 2024 presidential lean from the on-disk TLC r206 report (`scripts/diag_tx_safe_seat_backfill.py`). WA/NY/ID lower-chamber coverage was already complete. (This table is lower-chamber only for comparability; WA's all-seats figure including congressional + both House positions, and the 2016–2024 trend, are above.)

Robustness

`scripts/diag_safe_seat_robustness.py` .

The threshold doesn't matter. "Non-competitive" uses a 10-pt margin cut; the headline is flat across the whole plausible range, because the no-major-choice seats (a third or more of every chamber) are non-competitive at *any* threshold and only the contested seats move:

Lower chamber	≥5pt	≥8pt	≥10pt	≥12pt	≥15pt
WA House	95.9%	91.8%	88.8%	80.6%	78.6%
NY Assembly	94.6%	92.6%	88.6%	85.9%	82.6%
TX House	98.0%	96.0%	94.0%	91.3%	86.0%
ID House	95.7%	92.9%	92.9%	91.4%	90.0%

Even at a stringent **15-point** cut, **79–90%** of seats are non-competitive; at a loose 5-point cut, 95–98%. There is no threshold at which these chambers look competitive.

The contest gap — parties leave winnable seats on the table. Comparing each chamber's *actual-race* non-competitive share to the share of its districts that are ≥10-pt safe by **2024 presidential lean** (the partisan geography), where matched-boundary presidential results exist:

	Actual-race non-comp	Presidential-lean safe	Gap
WA House	88.8%	79.6%	**+9.2 pp**
TX House	94.0%	84.0%	**+10.0 pp**
ID House	92.9%	94.3%	−1.4 pp

In the two states with genuine partisan diversity (WA, TX), actual contestation is ~10 points *worse* than the map predicts — parties decline to field candidates even where the presidential numbers say the seat is winnable. In deep-one-party **Idaho** the gap vanishes (slightly negative): the districts are so lopsided presidentially that contestation cannot lag the map. So the "foregone-contest" pathology is **strongest where competition is actually possible** — which is the more troubling reading. (NY can't be tested here: its loaded presidential data ends in 2020, pre-2022 redistricting, so it can't be matched to the 2022 Assembly lines.)

Why it matters

The lead paper showed the off-year electorate is half-sized and old. This paper shows that even in the high-turnout even-year general, **most legislative and congressional seats are not actually in play** — so the real decision migrates to the **primary**, a round that draws about half the voters. Stack the two: a large share of Washington's representation is effectively chosen by **small, old, primary electorates**, with the November general a ratification. The reforms implied are the familiar pair — **on-cycle timing** (lead paper) to enlarge and rebalance the deciding electorate, and primary design (top-four / ranked-choice experiments) to put real choice back into the round that actually decides.

This paper makes no partisan-consequence claim: it counts contests and margins, not who benefits. That question needs individual party-of-record (the follow-on study).

Methods and limits

Full provenance + a no-AI reproduction recipe (every source, access path, and the exact scripts behind each figure): [Data Sources & Reproducibility](#).

- **Source.** `precinct_results` summed per candidate per seat; party from `candidates.party_normalized` (D = `%democrat%`, R = `%republican%` / `%gop%`), write-ins excluded; district parsed from `race_name`. Two-party margin = |D−R|/(D+R) among the major-party vote.
- **Seat universe.** State Representative Pos. 1 & 2 (every cycle), State Senator (staggered — only districts up that cycle, so the senate seat set varies by year), U.S. Representative. Even-year generals only (WA holds no legislative/congressional races in odd years).
- **Primary/general ratio** matches each general seat to its same-office, same-district August primary; "turnout" = total votes cast in that seat's race.
- Margins are observed two-party vote share, not the forecast. Third-party/independent votes are excluded from the margin but a lone third-party challenger still counts the seat as "contested" by headcount only if a major-party opponent is also present.